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After years of scraping by, a harvest arrives

For generations, women's cricket in India survived on goodwill, side hustles and improvised support. Now, after the World Cup win and the rise of the WPL, the game is living through an **unprecedented commercial bloom** that once felt unimaginable.

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Shubhangi Kulkarni was the bonafide star through the 1970s and 1980s, with locals flocking to cricket grounds to watch her take opponents to the cleaners.

Long before she occupied crucial decision-making positions within the BCCI, Shubhangi, even as a player, was tasked with finding sponsors for the very team she represented.

"It was really tough. We relied mostly on our contacts and not anyone's big vision for women's cricket," she tells *Sportstar*.

"I remember playing a match in Jalandhar in the 80s, which was a big export hub for cricketing equipment then. My family is into business and manufacturing, so I had an interest. I visited one of the factories and got the idea to open Sunny Sports Boutique, which I currently run.

"The Sunny brand brought out apparel which four top cricketers in the side — Shantha Rangaswamy, Sudha Shah, Sandhya Agarwal, and I — used."

This was around the time SG began sponsoring top men's players like Sunil Gavaskar. When the company expanded to include women, it was primarily to make kits available for free, a welcome relief to players operating in an era with no allowances or match fees.

Shubhangi's monetary struggles only deepened once she crossed into administration after retiring in 1991. India played Tests against Australia, New Zealand and others, albeit sporadically, in the following years. While acquaintances obliged her early requests as secretary of the Women's Cricket Association of India, funding for foreign tours and camps soon dried up, forcing Shubhangi to consider breaking some of her fixed deposits. Players often pooled in their own money, as former India captain Mithali Raj revealed later, to fund their international tours. The team also relied on help from NRI families in New Zealand as a last-ditch stay option during the 1995 tour, Nutan Gavaskar (Sunil's sister) and long-standing secretariat of the WCAI told media ahead of the final in Mumbai.

Names like Sahara eventually entered the fray, sponsoring the women's team in 2002. Broadcaster and actor Mandira Bedi took up the team's cause a few years later, funneling her advertising income into the women's side as its ambassador ahead of the 2005 World Cup.

In 2006, the WCAI merged with the BCCI after the International Women's Cricket Council united with the International Cricket Council.

In the two decades since, three major inflection points helped pull Indian women's cricket out of a prolonged monetary wilderness: the 2017 Women's World Cup, the launch of the Women's Premier League in 2023, and India's triumph in the 2025 Women's ODI World Cup.

The sleeping giant poked

The 2017 ODI showpiece was the first edition where every game was broadcast. It brought a fresh viewer base to the women's game, rewarded by one of the sport's biggest upsets when India cast Australia aside to reach the final. India fell short of a maiden ICC trophy by just nine runs, but India Inc. woke up. An estimated